highlights the emotional and experiential content of the NLD's oppositional identity. Throughout three party forums that day, candidates as well as local party members shared stories from the military period about disputes they experienced with local authorities who opposed various village social initiatives, as well as the perceived mistreatment of government doctors or teachers being sent to work in remote, rural areas without their consultation and without provision of transportation. These deeply personal stories evoked knowing cheers and claps from the assembled supporters, highlighting the role that these experiences of suppressed or unappreciated social action during the authoritarian period — often as individuals engaged in ostensibly 'apolitical' or *parahita* activities — play in the formation of supporters' deeply emotional oppositional political identity.

The synergistic relationship between small and big 'P' politics in central Myanmar is further demonstrated by the pivotal role religious authorities play in defining what is at stake in the ongoing political transition. This is particularly the case since the outbreak of inter-communal violence in Rakhine State in 2012, and the subsequent proliferation of monks and monasteries aligned with the Buddhist nationalist groups 969 and the Patriotic Association of Myanmar, or MaBaTha. As Brac de la Perriere argues (2015, p. 5), these Buddhist nationalist groups explicitly seek to conjoin three concepts of belonging essential to defining the domain of 'the political' in contemporary Myanmar: the nation (*amyo*), religion as faith professed by individuals (*batha*), and religion as teaching instituted in a 'social space' (*thathana*).

While it has long been common for people to offer their time to support monastic activities, such as preaching events, the relationship between monks and laity increasingly revolves around the various socially oriented projects patronized by monks, including Dhamma Schools, clinics, and ambulance services. Indeed, a notable feature of all MaBaTha-aligned monasteries in Taungoo is the active role that laity play in offering their time and money for activities broadly seen to propagate and put into practice Buddhist virtues of the 'value of life', including volunteering at clinics run out of the monastery, the coordination of flood appeals, or teaching at, cooking for, or managing Dhamma schools (see McCarthy forthcoming a).[8]

This ethic of Buddhist-imbued social work, and the notions of value and Buddhist nationalism that animate it, is frequently contrasted with